苏东坡在黄州

一个诗人最难的四年，和他最好的作品

Su Dongpo in Exile

A poet's four hardest years, and his finest work

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 6 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 黄州[1]城东有一片不大的山坡，本地人叫它“东坡[2]”。如今，人们一说起“东坡”，想到的往往不是这片山坡，而是一个人——苏东坡[3]。这个名字是他自己起的，就是从这片山坡来的。九百多年前，他在这里过了四年多很苦的日子，也写出了一生中最好的一些作品。故事里那个叫阿牛[4]的农家少年是编出来的，苏东坡在黄州的那些日子，却是真实的历史。

牢里的诗

2 1079年秋天，宋朝[5]的京城开封[6]，御史台[7]的牢里关着一个四十多岁的犯人。他叫苏轼[8]，是当时最有名的诗人之一。

1 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
2 东坡 *Dōngpō* the Eastern Slope
3 苏东坡 *Sū Dōngpō* Su Dongpo, i.e. Su Shi (1037–1101)
4 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
5 宋朝 *Sòngcháo* the Song dynasty (960–1279)
6 开封 *Kāifēng* Kaifeng, the Song capital
7 御史台 *Yùshǐtái* the Censorate
8 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name

East of the town of Huangzhou lies a small hillside that the locals call Dongpo, "the Eastern Slope". Today, when people hear "Dongpo", they usually think not of the hillside but of a man: Su Dongpo. He gave himself that name, and it came from this very hillside. More than nine hundred years ago he spent four hard years here, and wrote some of the finest work of his life. The farm boy A Niu in this story is invented, but Su Dongpo's days in Huangzhou are real history. 1

Poems in Prison

In the autumn of 1079, in the prison of the Censorate in Kaifeng, capital of the Song dynasty, sat a prisoner in his forties. His name was Su Shi, and he was one of the most famous poets of his day. 2

2 几个月前，他还在南方的湖州[1]当官，不料有人从他的诗里找出了一些句子，说他在批评皇帝和新法[2]。于是，京城派来的人冲进他家，像赶鸡赶狗一样，把他带走了。

3 御史台[3]的院子里有很多老树，树上住着成群的乌鸦[4]，所以人们也叫它“乌台[5]”。这个案子，后来就叫做“乌台诗案[6]”。在牢里，苏轼[7]每天都要被审问。审问的人拿着他的诗集，一首一首地问：这句是什么意思？那句是在说谁？他从来没想到，自己写的诗，有一天会变成自己的罪名。外面传来的消息一天比一天坏，他觉得，这一次恐怕活不成了。

4 据说，他和每天来送饭的大儿子苏迈[8]有一个约定：平时只送菜和肉；如果听到要判他死罪的消息，就送一条鱼来。

1 湖州 *Húzhōu* Huzhou, in Zhejiang
2 新法 *xīnfǎ* the New Policies (state reforms)
3 御史台 *Yùshǐtái* the Censorate
4 乌鸦 *wūyā* crow
5 乌台 *Wūtái* Crow Terrace, i.e. the Censorate
6 乌台诗案 *Wūtái Shī'àn* the Crow Terrace Poetry Case
7 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
8 苏迈 *Sū Mài* Su Mai, Su Shi's eldest son

A few months earlier he had still been serving as an official in Huzhou in the south, when, to his surprise, people dug lines out of his poems and claimed he was attacking the emperor and the New Policies. So men sent from the capital burst into his house and drove him off like a chicken or a dog. 2

Old trees grew in the Censorate's courtyard, with flocks of crows living in them, so people also called it the "Crow Terrace". The case later became known as the Crow Terrace Poetry Case. In prison Su Shi was interrogated every day. His interrogators held his collected poems and went through them one by one: What does this line mean? Who is that line about? He had never imagined that the poems he wrote would one day become the charges against him. The news from outside got worse by the day, and he felt that this time he would probably not come out alive. 3

It is said that he had an agreement with his eldest son, Su Mai, who brought him food every day: normally he would bring only vegetables and meat, but if he heard that his father was to be sentenced to death, he would bring a fish. 4

有一天，苏迈[†]有事要出城，便托别人替他送饭，却忘了说这个约定。那个人想让他吃得好一点儿，特意做了一条鱼送进去。苏轼[‡]打开饭盒，一看是鱼，脸色一下子白了。他以为这就是最后的消息，不禁流下了眼泪。

那天夜里，他给弟弟苏辙[§]写了两首诗，当作最后的告别。诗里有这样的句子：“是处青山可埋骨[¶]”——哪里的青山都可以埋我的骨头；“与君世世为兄弟[*]”——希望下辈子，下下辈子，还能和你做兄弟。他和弟弟从小一起读书，又在同一年考中了进士[#]，感情一直特别深。

不料，事情后来有了变化。

† 苏迈 *Sū Mài* Su Mai, Su Shi's eldest son

‡ 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name

§ 苏辙 *Sū Zhé* Su Zhe, Su Shi's younger brother

¶ 是处青山可埋骨 *shìchù qīngshān kě mái gǔ* any green hill may bury my bones

* 与君世世为兄弟 *yǔ jūn shìshì wéi xiōngdì* may we be brothers every life

进士 *jìnshì* jinshi, highest examination degree

One day Su Mai had to leave the city, so he asked someone else to bring the food in his place, but he forgot to mention the agreement. Wanting him to eat a little better, the man made a fish especially for him. When Su Shi opened the food box and saw a fish, the colour drained from his face. Thinking this was the final news, he could not hold back his tears. 4

That night he wrote two poems to his younger brother Su Zhe as a last farewell. In them were lines like these: "Any green hill will do to bury my bones", that is, any green hill anywhere can hold me; and "May you and I be brothers in every life to come", that is, in the next life, and the one after, I hope to be your brother again. He and his brother had studied together since childhood and passed the highest examination in the same year; they had always been very close. 5

Then, unexpectedly, things took a turn. 6

6 很多人为他说好话，据说连主张新法[1]的王安石[2]也劝皇帝不要杀这样有才能的人。也有人说，皇帝读到了他写给弟弟的诗，心也软了。这一年年底，苏轼[3]在牢里关了一百多天以后，终于被放了出来。他没有被杀，却被贬[4]到了长江[5]边的黄州[6]，当一个叫“团练副使[7]”的小官。这个官没有一点权力，什么事也不能管，也不能随便离开黄州。说是官，其实跟犯人差不多。

7 出了牢门，他看着冬天的太阳，觉得一切都像做梦一样。可是他刚回到住的地方，便又拿起笔写了两首诗。其中一句是“平生文字为吾累[8]”——一辈子写的文字，都成了我的麻烦。写完，他自己也不禁笑了：刚因为写诗差点儿死掉，怎么又写起来了？

1 新法 *xīnfǎ* the New Policies (state reforms)
2 王安石 *Wáng Ānshí* Wang Anshi, reforming statesman
3 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
4 贬 *biǎn* to demote and banish
5 长江 *Chángjiāng* the Yangtze River
6 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
7 团练副使 *tuánliàn fùshǐ* deputy militia commissioner
8 平生文字为吾累 *píngshēng wénzì wéi wú lěi* my writing has ruined my life

Many people spoke up for him; it is said that even Wang Anshi, the champion of the New Policies, urged the emperor not to kill a man of such talent. Others say the emperor read the poems to his brother and was moved. At the end of that year, after more than a hundred days in prison, Su Shi was finally released. He was not executed but banished to Huangzhou on the Yangtze, as a minor official with the title of "deputy militia commissioner". The post carried no power at all: he could take charge of nothing and could not leave Huangzhou as he pleased. An official in name, he was really little better than a prisoner. 6

Outside the prison gate, he looked at the winter sun and felt that everything was like a dream. Yet no sooner was he back where he was staying than he picked up his brush and wrote two more poems. One line ran: "All my life, my writing has been my undoing." When he had finished, even he could not help laughing: he had nearly died for writing poems, and here he was writing them again. 7

到黄州[1]

8 1080年正月[2]初一，别人家都在过年，苏轼[3]却带着苏迈[4]，冒着风雪离开了京城。他们一路往南，走了整整一个月，二月初一才到了黄州。那时候的黄州，是长江[5]边的一个小城，又穷又远。城里只有几条街，城外是山，是竹林，是一眼看不到头的大江。苏轼没有房子，只好先住进城东南的一座小寺，叫定惠院[6]。他跟寺里的人一起吃饭，白天常常关着门，晚上才一个人出来走走。

9 阿牛[7]第一次见到苏轼，就是在定惠院的后门外。那年阿牛十四岁，家住在城外，每隔几天就挑着青菜进城来卖。有一天晚上，天已经黑了，他看见一个穿着旧衣服的中年人一个人站在树下，抬头看着月亮，很久都不动。阿牛以为他是寺里新来的客人，就问："先生，要买菜吗？"

1 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
2 正月 *zhēngyuè* first lunar month
3 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
4 苏迈 *Sū Mài* Su Mai, Su Shi's eldest son
5 长江 *Chángjiāng* the Yangtze River
6 定惠院 *Dìnghuì Yuàn* Dinghui Temple
7 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)

Arriving in Huangzhou

On the first day of the first lunar month of 1080, while other families were 8
celebrating the New Year, Su Shi set out from the capital through wind and snow, taking Su Mai with him. They travelled south for a full month, and reached Huangzhou only on the first day of the second month. Huangzhou then was a small town on the Yangtze, poor and remote. Inside the walls there were only a few streets; outside were hills, bamboo groves, and a great river that stretched further than the eye could see. Having no house, he had to stay at first in a small temple in the south-east of the town, the Dinghui Temple. He ate with the monks, often kept his door shut during the day, and came out for walks alone only at night.

A Niu first saw Su Shi outside the back gate of the Dinghui Temple. That 9
year A Niu was fourteen. His family lived outside the town, and every few days he carried vegetables in on a shoulder pole to sell. One evening, after dark, he saw a middle-aged man in old clothes standing alone under a tree, looking up at the moon, not moving for a long time. Taking him for a new guest at the temple, A Niu asked, “Sir, would you like some vegetables?”

9 那人转过头来，看了看他的菜，笑了：“你这菜很新鲜。可惜，我现在买菜也得一个钱一个钱地算了。”

10 后来阿牛[†]才知道，这个人就是从京城来的大诗人苏轼[‡]。城里的人说，他犯了罪，是被皇帝赶到这里来的，最好离他远一点儿。苏轼自己好像也怕见人。老朋友们很少给他写信，他写给别人的信，也常常请人家看完就烧掉。毕竟，他刚因为几句诗差点儿丢了命。可是阿牛一点儿也不怕他。他觉得，这个人说话很客气，笑起来的样子，跟村里的老农民差不多。

11 苏轼到黄州[§]不久，写了一首诗，里面有两句：“长江绕郭知鱼美[¶]，好竹连山觉笋香[*]。”

† 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)

‡ 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name

§ 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei

¶ 长江绕郭知鱼美 *Chángjiāng rào guō zhī yú měi* river round the walls: fine fish

* 好竹连山觉笋香 *hǎo zhú lián shān jué sǔn xiāng* bamboo hills: fragrant shoots

The man turned, looked at his vegetables and smiled. "Your vegetables are very fresh. Unfortunately, these days I have to count every coin, even for vegetables." 9

Only later did A Niu learn that this man was the great poet Su Shi from the capital. People in the town said he had committed a crime and been driven here by the emperor, and that it was best to keep away from him. Su Shi himself seemed afraid of meeting people. His old friends seldom wrote to him, and in the letters he did write he often asked people to burn them once they had read them. After all, he had just nearly lost his life over a few lines of verse. But A Niu was not afraid of him at all. He thought the man spoke politely, and when he laughed he looked much like the old farmers in the village. 10

Soon after he arrived in Huangzhou, Su Shi wrote a poem containing these two lines: "The Yangtze rings the town walls: I know the fish will be good; fine bamboo covers the hills: I can smell the shoots already." 11

11 意思是：长江[1]绕着城流，这里的鱼一定很好吃；山上到处是竹子，竹笋[2]一定也很香。刚从牢里出来，他想的却是吃。阿牛[3]后来听人念这首诗，忍不住笑出了声。那年五月，苏辙[4]坐船把哥哥的家人送到了黄州[5]。全家搬进了江边一座叫临皋亭[6]的旧房子，那里原来是给过路的官住的。

12 人多，钱却少。苏轼[7]几乎没有收入了，只能靠以前存下的一点儿钱生活。他想了一个办法：每个月初一，拿出4500个铜钱，分成30串，挂在房梁上。每天早上，他用一根长叉子挑下一串，然后把叉子藏起来，一天最多只花 150 个钱。用不完的，就另外存起来，等朋友来的时候买酒。阿牛去送菜的时候，亲眼见过房梁上那一串一串的钱。他心里想：原来大诗人的日子，也跟我们农家一样难。

1 长江 *Chángjiāng* the Yangtze River
2 竹笋 *zhúsǔn* bamboo shoots
3 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
4 苏辙 *Sū Zhé* Su Zhe, Su Shi's younger brother
5 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
6 临皋亭 *Língāo Tíng* Lingao Pavilion, a riverside lodge
7 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name

That is: the Yangtze flows around the town, so the fish here must be delicious; 11
the hills are covered in bamboo, so the shoots must taste wonderful too. Fresh out of prison, and what he was thinking about was food. When A Niu later heard someone recite the poem, he burst out laughing. In the fifth month of that year, Su Zhe brought his brother's family to Huangzhou by boat. The family moved into an old building by the river called the Lingao Pavilion, which had once been a lodge for officials passing through.

Many mouths, little money. Su Shi had almost no income now, and the 12
family had to live on the little he had saved. He came up with a plan. On the first day of each month he took out 4,500 copper coins, divided them into thirty strings and hung them from the roof beam. Every morning he lifted down one string with a long forked pole and then hid the pole away; he never spent more than 150 coins a day. Whatever was left over he put aside, to buy wine with when friends came. When A Niu delivered vegetables, he saw the strings of coins hanging from the beam with his own eyes. He thought: so a great poet's life is just as hard as ours on the farm.

东坡†

13 可是，存下的钱总有用完的一天。到了第二年，也就是1081年，家里快吃不上饭了。这时，一个跟了他二十年的老朋友马正卿‡，替他向本地官府要来了一块地。地在城东的山坡上，大约有五十亩§，原来是一片旧兵营，已经很多年没有人管了，到处是野草和碎石头。

14 苏轼¶决定自己种地。一个读了一辈子书的人，便这样拿起了农具。阿牛*的父亲听说了，摇着头说："一个写字的先生，哪里会种地？"话虽然这么说，他还是让阿牛去帮忙，一天几个钱，管一顿饭。那年雨水很少，地又硬，挖一下就碰到石头。苏轼全家都来了：妻子王闰之#送水送饭，儿子们搬石头，他自己卷起袖子，跟阿牛一起挖地、拔草。

† 东坡 *Dōngpō* the Eastern Slope
‡ 马正卿 *Mǎ Zhèngqīng* Ma Zhengqing, Su Shi's loyal friend
§ 亩 *mǔ* mu (about 1/15 hectare)
¶ 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
* 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
\# 王闰之 *Wáng Rùnzhī* Wang Runzhi, Su Shi's wife

The Eastern Slope

But savings are bound to run out one day. By the second year, 1081, the 13
family was close to going hungry. At this point Ma Zhengqing, an old friend who had followed him for twenty years, obtained a plot of land for him from the local authorities. The land lay on the slope east of the town, roughly fifty mu. It had once been an army camp and had been left untended for years, overgrown with weeds and strewn with broken stones.

Su Shi decided to farm the land himself. And so a man who had spent his 14
whole life reading books took up farm tools. When A Niu's father heard about it, he shook his head. "A gentleman who writes — what does he know about farming?" For all that, he still sent A Niu to help, for a few coins a day and a meal. There was little rain that year and the ground was hard; every stroke hit stone. Su Shi's whole family came: his wife Wang Runzhi brought water and food, his sons carried stones, and he himself rolled up his sleeves and dug and weeded alongside A Niu.

14 没几天，这位大诗人的手上就起满了泡。

15 有一天，阿牛[†]在坡下烧干草。火灭了以后，草下面露出了一圈旧石头，中间黑黑的。他往下一看，竟然有水！“先生！有井！”他一边喊一边往坡上跑。苏轼[‡]跑下来一看，高兴得像个孩子。有了这口井，天再干，地也不怕了。后来，他把这件事写进了诗里：家里的孩子烧草，跑来告诉他，发现了一口藏着的井。阿牛一直相信，诗里那个孩子就是他。

16 低一点的地，他们种了水稻[§]；高一点的地，种了麦子；坡边上又种了一些果树。麦子长出来以后，绿得特别快。苏轼正高兴，一位老农民却说：“长得太快不是好事。您要是想吃饱饭，就得让牛羊进地里踩一踩。”苏轼听了，不但没有不高兴，反而认真地谢了他，后来还把老农民的话也写进了诗里。

† 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
‡ 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
§ 水稻 *shuǐdào* rice (paddy)

Within a few days the great poet's hands were covered in blisters. 14

One day A Niu was burning dry grass at the foot of the slope. When the fire 15
died down, a ring of old stones showed beneath the grass, dark in the middle. He looked down, and there was water! "Sir! There's a well!" he shouted as he ran up the slope. Su Shi ran down to look and was as happy as a child. With this well, the land would be safe however dry the weather. Later he put the event into a poem: a boy of the household, burning grass, came running to tell him that a hidden well had been found. A Niu always believed that the boy in the poem was him.

In the lower ground they planted rice, on the higher ground wheat, and 16
along the edges of the slope a few fruit trees. When the wheat came up, it turned green very fast. Su Shi was delighted, but an old farmer said, "Growing too fast is no good. If you want a full belly, you must let the cattle and sheep into the field to trample it a bit." Far from taking offence, Su Shi thanked him earnestly, and later put the old farmer's words into a poem as well.

17 他越来越喜欢这片山坡。唐朝[1]的大诗人白居易[2]当年在外地做官的时候，也在城东的山坡上种过花种过树，还写过好几首关于“东坡[3]”的诗。苏轼[4]也就把这块地叫作“东坡”，还给自己起了一个号，叫“东坡居士[5]”。第二年春天，他在坡上盖了几间房子。房子是在大雪中盖好的，他就在墙上画满了雪，叫它“雪堂[6]”。从那以后，“苏东坡[7]”这个名字越传越远，一直传到了今天。

一锅肉

18 黄州[8]养猪的人家很多，猪肉也便宜。可是有钱人看不起它，不愿意吃；穷人又不会做，煮出来又难吃又硬。阿牛[9]家一年也吃不了几次肉。他母亲常说，猪肉那东西，煮不好还不如青菜。

1 唐朝 *Tángcháo* the Tang dynasty (618–907)
2 白居易 *Bái Jūyì* Bai Juyi, Tang poet
3 东坡 *Dōngpō* the Eastern Slope
4 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
5 东坡居士 *Dōngpō Jūshì* the Recluse of the Eastern Slope
6 雪堂 *Xuětáng* the Snow Hall
7 苏东坡 *Sū Dōngpō* Su Dongpo, i.e. Su Shi (1037–1101)
8 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
9 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)

He grew fonder and fonder of this hillside. When the great Tang poet Bai Juyi had served as an official far from the capital, he too had planted flowers and trees on a slope east of his town and written several poems about his "Eastern Slope". So Su Shi, too, called his land the Eastern Slope, and gave himself the literary name "the Recluse of the Eastern Slope". The next spring he built a few rooms on the slope. They were finished during a heavy snowfall, so he painted snow all over the walls and called the place the Snow Hall. From then on, the name "Su Dongpo" spread further and further, all the way down to the present day. 17

A Pot of Pork

Many households in Huangzhou kept pigs, and pork was cheap. But the rich looked down on it and would not eat it, while the poor did not know how to cook it; boiled, it came out tough and nasty. A Niu's family had meat only a few times a year. His mother often said that pork, badly cooked, was worse than greens. 18

18 有一天，苏轼†从集市上提回一大块猪肉，笑着对阿牛‡说：“今天不干活了，你来帮我烧火。”

19 他把肉切成大块，放进锅里，只加了一点点水和酒，然后让阿牛把火弄小，越小越好。阿牛着急了：“先生，火这么小，什么时候才能熟啊？”苏轼不慌不忙§地说：“别急。做这肉，就跟过日子一样，急不得。火候¶到了，它便自己香了。”说完，他就坐在火边看起书来，一看就是半天。

20 天快黑的时候，锅一打开，一股香气冲了出来。肉变成了红亮的颜色，用筷子一夹就开，放进嘴里，又软又香。阿牛吃了一块，又吃了一块，不禁叫了起来：“这真是我们黄州*的猪肉吗？”

† 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
‡ 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
§ 不慌不忙 *bùhuāng bùmáng* calm and unhurried
¶ 火候 *huǒhou* cooking time and heat
* 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei

One day Su Shi came back from the market carrying a big slab of pork and said 18
to A Niu with a smile, "No farm work today. Come and help me tend the fire."

He cut the meat into big chunks, put them in the pot with just a little water 19
and wine, and then told A Niu to make the fire small, the smaller the better. A Niu grew impatient. "Sir, with a fire this small, when will it ever be done?" Su Shi answered calmly, "Don't rush. Cooking this meat is like living your life: it can't be hurried. When the heat has done its work, it will turn fragrant all by itself." With that he sat down by the fire and began to read, and stayed there for half the day.

As darkness fell they opened the pot, and a rich aroma burst out. The meat 20
had turned a glossy red; it came apart at the touch of the chopsticks, and in the mouth it was soft and fragrant. A Niu ate one piece, then another, and could not help crying out, "Is this really our Huangzhou pork?"

20 苏轼[1]哈哈大笑。他写过一篇短短的《猪肉颂[2]》，一般认为就是在黄州[3]写的。里面说：“少著水[4]，……待他自熟莫催他[5]，火候足时他自美[6]。”他还说，每天早上来上两碗，自己吃饱了就好，别人怎么想，不用管。

21 今天，中国很多饭馆都有一道菜，叫“东坡肉[7]”。关于这道菜是怎么来的，有不少传说。最有名的一个说，很多年以后，苏东坡[8]在杭州[9]当官，带人清理西湖[10]，老百姓送来很多猪肉感谢他，他就让人按黄州的做法烧好，再送给干活的人吃。这只是传说，不一定是真的。可是那道菜最早的味道，也许真是从黄州的那口小锅里来的。

1 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
2 猪肉颂 *Zhūròu Sòng* In Praise of Pork
3 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
4 少著水 *shǎo zhuó shuǐ* use little water
5 待他自熟莫催他 *dài tā zì shú mò cuī tā* let it cook, don't hurry it
6 火候足时他自美 *huǒhou zú shí tā zì měi* cooked long enough, it's delicious
7 东坡肉 *Dōngpōròu* Dongpo pork (braised pork belly)
8 苏东坡 *Sū Dōngpō* Su Dongpo, i.e. Su Shi (1037–1101)
9 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou
10 西湖 *Xīhú* West Lake

Su Shi roared with laughter. He wrote a short piece, In Praise of Pork, generally 20
thought to date from his Huangzhou years. It says: "Use little water... wait for it to cook by itself and do not hurry it; when the heat has done its work, it turns delicious on its own." He added that he would have two bowls every morning; as long as he was full, never mind what anyone else thought.

Today many restaurants in China serve a dish called Dongpo pork. There 21
are many legends about how the dish came about. The best known says that years later, when Su Dongpo was an official in Hangzhou and had men clearing out West Lake, the people sent him a great deal of pork in thanks, and he had it cooked the Huangzhou way and given to the workers. It is only a legend and may not be true. But the dish's original flavour may well have come out of that little pot in Huangzhou.

雨中的路

22 日子并不总是这么轻松。1082年春天，黄州[1]的雨下了两个多月。临皋亭[2]的房子又小又湿，江水涨得快要进门了，厨房里只剩下一点冷菜。寒食节[3]那天，苏轼[4]写了两首诗，开头就说："自我来黄州[5]，已过三寒食[6]。"诗里的他又老又病，头发也白了，心就像"死灰吹不起[7]"——火灭了以后剩下的东西，怎么吹也吹不起来了。他写下这两首诗的字，后来成了有名的书法作品《寒食帖[8]》。

23 可是，他并没有被这场雨打败。随着天气慢慢变暖，他又开始出门了。

1 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
2 临皋亭 *Língāo Tíng* Lingao Pavilion, a riverside lodge
3 寒食节 *Hánshíjié* Cold Food Festival
4 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
5 自我来黄州 *zì wǒ lái Huángzhōu* since I came to Huangzhou
6 已过三寒食 *yǐ guò sān Hánshí* three Cold Food days have passed
7 死灰吹不起 *sǐhuī chuī bù qǐ* dead ashes won't rekindle
8 寒食帖 *Hánshí Tiě* the Cold Food Observance scroll

The Road in the Rain

Life was not always so carefree. In the spring of 1082 it rained in Huangzhou 22
for more than two months. The rooms at the Lingao Pavilion were small and damp, the river rose until it nearly came in at the door, and there was little left in the kitchen but some cold greens. On the day of the Cold Food Festival Su Shi wrote two poems, which begin: "Since I came to Huangzhou, three Cold Food Festivals have passed." In the poems he is old and sick, his hair gone white, and his heart is like "dead ashes that cannot be blown back to flame": what is left after a fire goes out, which no amount of blowing will rekindle. The scroll on which he wrote out these two poems later became a famous work of calligraphy, the Cold Food Observance.

But the rain did not defeat him. As the weather slowly grew warmer, he 23
began to go out again.

23 那年三月初七，他听说城东南三十里外的沙湖[†]有地要卖，就和几个朋友一起去看地。阿牛[‡]认识路，也跟着去了。去的时候天气很好，大家在路上还喝了一点酒。

24 回来的路上，拿着雨具的人已经先走了，不料一阵大雨说来就来，打在路边的竹叶上，响成一片。同行的人一下子都乱了，有的用袖子挡着头，有的往树下跑，一个个全身湿透，样子很难看。阿牛也想跑，回头一看，却站住了：苏轼[§]拿着一根细竹子，穿着草鞋，在大雨里慢慢地走着，嘴里还在轻轻地念着什么。“先生，快跑啊！”阿牛喊。“跑什么？”苏轼笑着说，“前面也在下雨。反正已经湿了，不如慢慢走。再说，雨毕竟是会停的。”阿牛想了想，觉得很有道理，便也放慢了脚步，跟在他身后走。

† 沙湖 *Shāhú* Shahu, south-east of Huangzhou

‡ 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)

§ 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name

On the seventh day of the third month that year, he heard that there was land 23
for sale at Shahu, thirty li south-east of the town, and went with a few friends to look at it. A Niu knew the way, so he went along too. On the way out the weather was fine, and they even drank a little wine as they went.

On the way back, the servants with the rain gear had already gone on ahead 24
when, without warning, a heavy shower came down, drumming loudly on the bamboo leaves by the road. His companions were thrown into confusion: some covered their heads with their sleeves, some ran for the trees, and every one of them was soaked through and looked a sorry sight. A Niu wanted to run too, but when he looked back he stopped short: Su Shi, holding a thin bamboo stick and wearing straw sandals, was strolling along in the downpour, murmuring something to himself. "Sir, run!" A Niu shouted. "What for?" said Su Shi with a smile. "It's raining up ahead too. We're wet already, so we may as well take our time. Besides, the rain will stop eventually." A Niu thought about it, decided he was right, and slowed his pace to walk behind him.

25 没走多远，雨果然停了。一阵冷风吹来，苏轼[1]路上喝的酒也醒了，身上有点儿冷。可是一抬头，山头上的太阳已经斜斜地照了过来，好像在迎接他们。后来，他把这场雨写成了一首词，叫《定风波[2]》。里面有这样几句："竹杖芒鞋轻胜马[3]，谁怕？一蓑烟雨任平生[4]。"意思是：拿着竹子，穿着草鞋，比骑马还轻快。怕什么？披上一件蓑衣[5]，风里雨里，就这样过一辈子。

26 词的最后几句是："回首向来萧瑟处[6]，归去[7]，也无风雨也无晴[8]。"回头看刚才风吹雨打的地方，现在已经说不上有风有雨，也说不上是晴天了。阿牛[9]不懂什么是词，可是他一直记得那天的样子：大家都在跑，只有一个人，在雨里慢慢地走。

1 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
2 定风波 *Dìngfēngbō* Calming the Waves (a ci tune)
3 竹杖芒鞋轻胜马 *zhúzhàng mángxié qīng shèng mǎ* staff and sandals, lighter than a horse
4 一蓑烟雨任平生 *yī suō yānyǔ rèn píngshēng* a rain cape for a lifetime
5 蓑衣 *suōyī* straw rain cape
6 回首向来萧瑟处 *huíshǒu xiànglái xiāosè chù* looking back where the storm was
7 归去 *guīqù* going home
8 也无风雨也无晴 *yě wú fēngyǔ yě wú qíng* neither storm nor sunshine
9 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)

Before they had gone far, the rain did indeed stop. A cold gust blew, sober- 25
ing Su Shi from the wine he had drunk on the way, and he felt a little chilly. But when he looked up, the sun on the hilltop was already slanting towards them, as if to welcome them. Later he turned that shower into a song lyric, "Calming the Waves". In it are these lines: "Bamboo staff and straw sandals, lighter than a horse: who's afraid? In a straw cape through mist and rain, I'll take whatever life may bring." That is: with a bamboo stick and straw sandals I go more lightly than on horseback. What is there to fear? Throw on a straw cape and go through wind and rain like this for the rest of my life.

The lyric ends with these lines: "I look back at the place where the wind and 26
rain were wailing; going home, there is neither storm nor sunshine." Looking back at the place where wind and rain had lashed them a moment ago, one could no longer call it stormy, nor call it fine. A Niu did not know what a song lyric was, but he always remembered how that day looked: everyone running, and just one man walking slowly in the rain.

赤壁[1]之[2]夜

27 黄州[3]城外的江边，有一片红色的石壁，本地人叫它“赤壁”。有人说，这里就是三国[4]故事里赤壁之战[5]的地方：公元 208 年，周瑜[6]用火烧了曹操[7]的船，打败了曹操的大军。其实，真正的战场很可能在黄州西边，离这里有好几百里。苏轼[8]自己大概也知道这一点。

28 1082年七月十六，月亮正圆。苏轼和几个客人坐着一条小船，到赤壁下面去玩，阿牛[9]帮他们划船。江上的风轻轻地吹来，水平得像一面镜子。苏轼后来写道：“清风徐来[10]，水波不兴[11]。”

1 赤壁 *Chìbì* Red Cliff
2 之 *zhī* (classical) of
3 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
4 三国 *Sānguó* the Three Kingdoms era
5 赤壁之战 *Chìbì zhī Zhàn* the Battle of Red Cliffs (208)
6 周瑜 *Zhōu Yú* Zhou Yu, general of Wu
7 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao, northern warlord
8 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
9 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
10 清风徐来 *qīngfēng xú lái* a cool breeze comes gently
11 水波不兴 *shuǐbō bù xīng* the water lies unruffled

A Night at Red Cliff

Outside Huangzhou, on the riverbank, stands a red rock face that the locals 27
call Red Cliff. Some said this was the site of the Battle of Red Cliffs from the stories of the Three Kingdoms: in 208, Zhou Yu set fire to Cao Cao's ships and defeated his great army. In fact, the real battlefield was very probably several hundred li to the west, upriver from Huangzhou. Su Shi himself most likely knew this.

On the sixteenth day of the seventh month of 1082, the moon was full. Su Shi 28
and a few guests took a small boat out below Red Cliff, with A Niu rowing for them. A breeze blew gently over the river, and the water was as flat as a mirror. Su Shi later wrote: "A cool breeze comes gently; the water lies unruffled."

28 大家喝着酒，唱着歌。一个客人拿出箫[†]吹了起来，声音又低又长，像有人在哭，又像有人在说心里的话。阿牛[‡]听着听着，心里也难过起来。

29 苏轼[§]问："你的箫声怎么这么伤心？"客人说："当年曹操[¶]的船从这里经过，一眼看不到头，他是多么了不起的英雄！可是现在，他在哪儿呢？我们这些人在这么大的世界里，就像只活一天的小虫子，像大海里的一颗米。人生这么短，长江[*]却永远流不完。"

30 苏轼指着江水和月亮说："你看这水，一直在流，可是从来没有流走；你看这月亮，有时候圆，有时候缺，可是也从来没有多一点、少一点。从变的一面看，什么都一下子就变了；从不变的一面看，我们和万物都不会完，又何必[#]为长江伤心呢？"

† 箫 *xiāo* xiao, vertical bamboo flute
‡ 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
§ 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
¶ 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao, northern warlord
* 长江 *Chángjiāng* the Yangtze River
何必 *hébì* why must, there's no need

They drank and sang. One of the guests took out a flute and began to play; its notes were low and long, like someone weeping, or someone pouring out his heart. As A Niu listened, he too grew sad. 28

Su Shi asked, "Why does your flute sound so sad?" The guest said, "When Cao Cao's ships passed this way, they stretched further than the eye could see. What a hero he was! And where is he now? We people in this vast world are like little insects that live for a single day, like one grain of rice in the sea. Life is so short, and yet the Yangtze flows on for ever." 29

Su Shi pointed at the river and the moon. "Look at this water: it flows on and on, yet it has never flowed away. Look at the moon: sometimes full, sometimes waning, yet it has never grown by a bit or shrunk by a bit. Seen from the side of change, everything changes in an instant; seen from the side of what does not change, we and all things are without end. So why grieve over the Yangtze?" 30

30 他又说：“江上的清风，山间的明月，耳朵听到了就是声音，眼睛看到了就是颜色。谁都可以拿，谁也不会不让你拿，用多少也用不完。这是老天送给我们的，我们一起享受吧。”客人听了，笑了起来。大家又喝起酒来，最后都在船上睡着了，不知道东方已经白了。

31 后来，苏轼[1]把这一夜写成了一篇赋[2]。三个月以后，他又去了一次赤壁[3]，又写了一篇。后来的人把它们叫作《前赤壁赋[4]》和《后赤壁赋[5]》。大约在同一年，他还写了一首词《念奴娇[6]·赤壁怀古[7]》，开头是：“大江东去[8]，浪淘尽[9]，千古风流人物[10]。”

1 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
2 赋 *fù* fu, rhymed prose
3 赤壁 *Chìbì* Red Cliff
4 前赤壁赋 *Qián Chìbì Fù* First Ode on Red Cliff
5 后赤壁赋 *Hòu Chìbì Fù* Second Ode on Red Cliff
6 念奴娇 *Niànnújiāo* Niannujiao (a ci tune)
7 赤壁怀古 *Chìbì Huáigǔ* Remembering the Past at Red Cliff
8 大江东去 *dàjiāng dōng qù* the great river flows east
9 浪淘尽 *làng táo jìn* its waves have washed away
10 千古风流人物 *qiāngǔ fēngliú rénwù* the heroes of all ages

He went on: "The cool breeze on the river and the bright moon over the hills: 30
what the ear catches becomes sound, what the eye meets becomes colour. Anyone may take them, no one will stop you, and however much you use, they never run out. They are Heaven's gift to us; let us enjoy them together." The guest laughed when he heard this. They drank again, and in the end all fell asleep in the boat, not knowing that the east had already turned white.

Later Su Shi wrote up that night as a piece of rhymed prose. Three months 31
afterwards he went to Red Cliff again and wrote a second. Later readers called them the First and Second Odes on Red Cliff. At about the same time he also wrote a song lyric, "Remembering the Past at Red Cliff", to the tune Niannujiao. It begins: "The great river flows east; its waves have washed away the heroes of a thousand ages."

31 接着又说：“故垒西边[1]，人道是[2]，三国周郎赤壁[3]。”“人道是”，就是“人们说这里是”。他并没有说这就是真的战场，只说是别人这么说。可是真的也好，假的也好，从那以后，黄州[4]的赤壁[5]就因为他的文章出了名，人们叫它“东坡赤壁[6]”。

离开

32 1084年春天，京城来了命令：苏轼[7]被调到汝州[8]。新的官还是一个没有权力的小官，可是汝州离京城近多了。大家都明白，这说明皇帝已经不那么生气了。据说，皇帝亲自写了一句话，意思是：人才难得，我不忍心一直不用他。

1 故垒西边 *gùlěi xībian* west of the old ramparts
2 人道是 *rén dào shì* people say it is
3 三国周郎赤壁 *Sānguó Zhōu láng Chìbì* young Zhou Yu's Red Cliff
4 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
5 赤壁 *Chìbì* Red Cliff
6 东坡赤壁 *Dōngpō Chìbì* Dongpo's Red Cliff
7 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
8 汝州 *Rǔzhōu* Ruzhou, in Henan

Then it goes on: "West of the old ramparts, people say, is the Red Cliff of young 31
Zhou Yu in the Three Kingdoms." "People say" means "people say it is here". He did not claim it was the real battlefield; he only said that others said so. But real or not, from then on Huangzhou's Red Cliff became famous because of his writing, and people call it "Dongpo's Red Cliff".

Leaving

In the spring of 1084 an order came from the capital: Su Shi was to be trans- 32
ferred to Ruzhou. The new post was still a minor one without power, but Ruzhou was much closer to the capital. Everyone understood that the emperor was no longer so angry. It is said that the emperor wrote in his own hand words to this effect: talent is rare, and I cannot bear to cast him aside for good.

33 这本来是好消息，苏轼[1]却高兴不起来。他已经在黄州[2]住了四年多，东坡[3]上的麦子又快熟了，雪堂[4]前的小树也长高了。他写了一首词告别黄州的邻居，第一句就问："归去来兮[5]，吾归何处[6]？"——回去吧，可是我的家到底在哪里呢？他的老家在万里以外的四川[7]。他在词里请邻居们别剪雪堂前那些细树枝，还请他们有空的时候，替他晒一晒打鱼穿的蓑衣[8]。好像他只是出一趟远门，很快就会回来。

34 走的那天，江边站满了送他的人：有一起喝过酒的朋友，有卖酒的、卖药的，也有种地的农民。四年前，大家都躲着这个"犯人"；四年后，大家反而舍不得他走了。阿牛[9]已经十八岁了，长得又高又结实。他挤到前面，把一包新茶塞到苏轼手里，却说不出话来。

1 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
2 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
3 东坡 *Dōngpō* the Eastern Slope
4 雪堂 *Xuětáng* the Snow Hall
5 归去来兮 *guī qù lái xī* let me go home
6 吾归何处 *wú guī hé chù* but where is my home
7 四川 *Sìchuān* Sichuan
8 蓑衣 *suōyī* straw rain cape
9 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)

33 It should have been good news, but Su Shi could not feel glad. He had lived in Huangzhou for more than four years; the wheat on the Eastern Slope was nearly ripe again, and the young trees in front of the Snow Hall had grown tall. He wrote a song lyric to bid farewell to his Huangzhou neighbours, and its first line asks: "Let me go home! But where is home for me?" Go back, yes, but where exactly was his home? His native place was in Sichuan, ten thousand li away. In the lyric he asked the neighbours not to cut the slender branches in front of the Snow Hall, and to sun his fishing cape for him now and then when they had time. It was as if he were only going on a long trip and would soon be back.

34 On the day he left, the riverbank was crowded with people seeing him off: friends he had drunk with, the wine seller and the medicine seller, and farmers too. Four years before, everyone had avoided this "criminal"; four years later, they could not bear to let him go. A Niu was eighteen now, tall and sturdy. He pushed his way to the front and pressed a packet of new tea into Su Shi's hands, but could not get a word out.

34 苏轼[1]拍了拍他："四年前来的时候，我以为会死在这里；不料，这里给了我这么多朋友。东坡[2]就交给你了。井是你找到的，地也是你帮我开的。我的蓑衣[3]，你也记得替我晒。"船慢慢开远了。阿牛[4]站在江边，一直看到船变成了一个小黑点。

35 苏轼再也没有回过黄州[5]。随着皇帝去世，京城里的情况变了，他回到京城，当过很大的官。不料没过几年，他又被贬[6]了，而且一次比一次远：先到了南方的惠州[7]，后来又到了海那边的儋州[8]。1101年，他终于可以回北方了，却在路上病倒，死在了常州[9]。去世前不久，他看到别人为他画的像，写下了这样两句："问汝平生功业[10]，黄州惠州儋州[11]。"

1 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi, Su Dongpo's real name
2 东坡 *Dōngpō* the Eastern Slope
3 蓑衣 *suōyī* straw rain cape
4 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
5 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
6 贬 *biǎn* to demote and banish
7 惠州 *Huìzhōu* Huizhou, in Guangdong
8 儋州 *Dānzhōu* Danzhou, on Hainan Island
9 常州 *Chángzhōu* Changzhou, in Jiangsu
10 问汝平生功业 *wèn rǔ píngshēng gōngyè* ask what my life achieved
11 黄州惠州儋州 *Huángzhōu Huìzhōu Dānzhōu* Huangzhou, Huizhou, Danzhou

Su Shi patted him. "When I came here four years ago, I thought I would die here. Who would have thought this place would give me so many friends? I'm leaving the Eastern Slope to you. You found the well, and you helped me clear the land. And remember to sun my rain cape for me." The boat slowly moved away. A Niu stood on the bank and watched until it became a little black dot. 34

Su Shi never went back to Huangzhou. With the emperor's death, things in the capital changed; he returned there and held high office. But unexpectedly, within a few years he was banished again, each time further away: first to Huizhou in the far south, then across the sea to Danzhou. In 1101 he was at last allowed to come north again, but he fell ill on the way and died in Changzhou. Shortly before his death, looking at a portrait someone had painted of him, he wrote these two lines: "If you ask what I achieved in my life: Huangzhou, Huizhou, Danzhou." 35

35 问他这一辈子做成了什么，他的回答不是当过的大官，而是三个被贬[1]去的地方。第一个，就是黄州[2]。那里的苦日子没有把他打败，反而让他成了苏东坡[3]。

36 苏东坡去世的消息传到黄州的时候，阿牛[4]已经是个三十多岁的农民了。那天下着小雨。他没有打伞，把那件一直替先生留着的旧蓑衣[5]披在身上，一个人走上了东坡[6]。雪堂[7]已经旧了，那口井还在，井里的水还是那么清。雨打在竹叶上，沙沙地响。他想起那年春天，大家都在跑，只有先生笑着说："跑什么？"走到坡顶的时候，雨停了。阿牛回过头，看着刚才走过的路，不禁轻轻地念出了那一句："也无风雨也无晴[8]。"

1 贬 *biǎn* to demote and banish
2 黄州 *Huángzhōu* Huangzhou, today's Huanggang, Hubei
3 苏东坡 *Sū Dōngpō* Su Dongpo, i.e. Su Shi (1037–1101)
4 阿牛 *Ā Niú* A Niu, a farm boy (fictional)
5 蓑衣 *suōyī* straw rain cape
6 东坡 *Dōngpō* the Eastern Slope
7 雪堂 *Xuětáng* the Snow Hall
8 也无风雨也无晴 *yě wú fēngyǔ yě wú qíng* neither storm nor sunshine

Asked what his life had amounted to, his answer was not the high offices 35
he had held but the three places he had been banished to. The first was Huangzhou. The hard years there had not defeated him; instead they had made him Su Dongpo.

When the news of Su Dongpo's death reached Huangzhou, A Niu was a 36
farmer in his thirties. It was drizzling that day. He did not take an umbrella; instead he threw on the old rain cape he had kept all these years for his master, and climbed the Eastern Slope alone. The Snow Hall had grown old, but the well was still there, its water as clear as ever. The rain pattered on the bamboo leaves. He remembered that spring day when everyone was running and only his master had said with a smile, "What for?" By the time he reached the top of the slope, the rain had stopped. A Niu turned and looked back down the path he had just climbed, and found himself softly saying that line: "Neither storm nor sunshine."